Who Represents the Destination, and What Do They Evaluate? Social-Media Posts about Qingdao

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Abstract. ~~Destination marketers and researchers frequently interpret social-media posts~~ Social-media posts are often read as direct proxies for ~~the destination imageheld by tourists. Conceptualizing~~ tourists' destination image. Treating posts as produced discourse rather than static cognitive images, ~~this extended abstract examines~~ we examine how institutional accounts and individual creators portray a single destination, Qingdao. ~~We cleaned 19, 099 posts and retained~~ After cleaning, 10,178 ~~for formal use on four platforms,after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped~~of 11,599 Qingdao tourism-related posts from four platforms were retained as destination-relevant. In a pilot ~~analysis~~ of 100 posts (476 segments), practical trip-planning information ~~predominated~~ (58% of segments) ~~, whereas~~ outweighed affective and sensory ~~expressions were less frequent~~ expression (30%). ~~Evaluations of core attractions were overwhelmingly favourable~~ Core attractions were evaluated overwhelmingly favourably (155 of 166 evaluations), whereas operational ~~aspects—price~~aspects (price, service, accessibility, and ~~crowding—were evenly divided~~ crowding) were evenly split (20 favourable vs. 19 unfavourable). ~~The subsequent stage investigates whether institutional and individual creator groups project divergent destination images from identical resources.~~

Keywords: destination image · user-generated content · content creators · content analysis.

1 Background

Destination image ~~comprises the cumulative beliefs and impressions an individual holds about a place, which cannot be reduced to simple aggregate content frequencies [6] . While~~ is an interactive system of thoughts, opinions, feelings, visualizations, and intentions toward a destination [6], which content frequency counts capture only in part. Image forms through induced, autonomous, and organic information agents [2]; social-media ~~posts provide foundational material for image formation [2]~~posts now act as such agents and can be coded for cognitive and affective attributes [1], but an online post is not ~~identical~~ equivalent to the internal ~~cognitive image held by a visitor . Prior research contrasting official marketing~~ image a visitor holds. Studies such as [5] compare official marketing (projected image) with tourist-generated content ~~has largely focused on thematic presence via word-frequency metrics [5]. Consequently, less~~ (perceived image) by the themes each contains. Less is known about ~~discursive variations in how destinations are represented: what pragmatic~~ the functions a post ~~serves~~performs, which attributes it evaluates, and how creator identity shapes ~~the narrative~~both.

2 Purpose

~~This study investigates~~ We compare how institutional accounts and individual creators represent Qingdao~~by examining~~ : their communicative strategies, the ~~specific~~ resources and attributes ~~evaluated, and their co-occurrence within discrete~~ they evaluate, and how these co-occur within text segments. We hypothesize that, even when depicting identical destination resources, institutional posts ~~consistently lean toward uncritical, promotionalrepresentations~~stay uncritically promotional, whereas individual creators ~~temper generally positive accounts with pragmatic~~ balance positive portrayals with practical caveats, critiques, or advice.

3 Method

We employedtheory-driven structured content analysis ~~[3]. Segments are produced by semantic segmentation of the post text, and each segment is coded for rhetorical~~ [4]. Before coding, embedding-based semantic segmentation (Qwen3-Embedding-8B) under fixed boundary rules divided each post into self-contained units of meaning; coders did not alter the boundaries. Each segment was coded for communicative strategy, target destination resource, evaluative attribute, and ~~the~~ evaluative valence and intensity~~of the evaluation~~. Account metadata ~~are catalogued independently of textual codes~~were coded separately, and creator grouping criteria were ~~pre-registered before inspecting comparative group outcomes. Trained~~ fixed before any group comparison. A relevance classifier trained on 1,300 ~~annotated posts , the cleaning model retained 10~~manually labelled posts screened the 11,~~178 posts for formal use on four platforms , after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped. The pilot sample was coded independently by two trained human coders (inter-coder reliability~~ 599 Qingdao tourism-related posts collected from four platforms and retained 10,178 as destination-relevant. Two trained coders independently coded the pilot (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.82$ for evaluative direction~~reached Cohen's $\kappa = 0.82$) , with discrepancies resolved through consensus discussions to establish the final labels~~) and resolved disagreements by discussion.

4 Results to Date

~~*Filtering destination-relevant content.* Of 19,099 cleaned posts, 10,178 on four platforms were retained for formal use after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped. Keyword-matched counts therefore overstate the posts actually used.~~

What posts do. The pilot ~~sample~~ covers 100 randomly sampled posts ~~across~~ (476 segments). Practical information (itineraries, pricing, how-to advice) appears in 58% of segments, sensory or emotional ~~rendering~~ expression in 30%, background knowledge in 11%, and calls for interaction in 3%. ~~Approximately~~ About half of the posts ~~convey~~ give explicit recommendations.

What posts ~~judge~~evaluate. The ~~two human coders concurred on both the target attribute and evaluative valence across~~ coders agreed on both attribute and valence for 216 evaluations. Core attraction quality, activities, and destination atmosphere accounted for 166 evaluations (155 favourable vs. 10 unfavourable). ~~Conversely~~By contrast, operational factors—price, service, facilities, accessibility, crowding, and management—accounted for 44~~evaluations, with sentiment~~ , evenly split (20 favourable vs. 19 unfavourable).

~~*Where categories blur.* The coders diverged most frequently on whether visiting a landmark constitutes an activity versus a sight, and whether specific architectural structures function as scenic sights or service facilities. Consequently, the refined coding codebook explicitly separates scenic architectural attractions from functional hospitality facilities.~~

5 Significance

~~For destination marketing organizations (DMOs), this pilot untangles critical operational nuances that aggregate sentiment scores obscure. Favourable evaluations predominantly attach~~ Praise attaches mostly to endowed destination assets, whereas ~~complaints concentrate~~ criticism concentrates on manageable operational touchpoints~~; thus, actionable managerial signals reside within~~ , so the actionable signal for destination marketing organizations (DMOs) lies in roughly one-fifth of ~~all evaluations. Furthermore, posts function predominantly as pragmatic travel-planning utilities rather than purely affective personal reflections. If subsequent full-sample analysis confirms that individual creators absorb and project operational critiques while institutional accounts omit them, the two cohorts effectively construct divergent destinations from the same underlying resources. Aligned~~ evaluations, which aggregate sentiment scores obscure. In line with the conference theme ~~of Hype and Return, our methodology demonstrates where computational automation delivers efficiency and where rigorous human discernment remains indispensable.~~ (*Shaping Tourism Technology: Hype, Human Centricity and ROI*), our workflow leaves high-volume filtering and segmentation to models and interpretive judgement to human coders. Social-listening tools that report sentiment by attribute and creator type would show DMOs where operational investment pays off.

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